SCAM DECODED · FREE HOLIDAY CONVERSATION GUIDE

Scam-Proof Your Parents This Holiday

One 30-minute conversation, while you're home. What to say, what to set up together, and what to leave on the fridge.

You'll be at the table together anyway. Thirty minutes this visit can save a phone call you never want to get. This guide gives you the openers, a 4-step plan, word-for-word answers to the 6 scam calls older adults get most, and a family plan to fill in before you leave.

1 Start it without a lecture

Nobody likes being told they're an easy target. Make it about the scammers, or about you.

TRY THIS
"I got the weirdest text this week pretending to be my bank. Have you been getting those?"

TRY THIS
"Scammers can copy voices now. Can we pick a family word, so nobody can fake being me?"

TRY THIS
"My friend's dad lost money to a call that sounded exactly like his bank. Can I show you what they said?"

SKIP THIS
"You need to be more careful." It sounds like blame, and the conversation ends.

SKIP THIS
"Old people always fall for this." Anyone can, and scammers target all ages.

SKIP THIS
Taking their phone and changing settings without asking. Do it together, so they know what changed.

If they say "I'd never fall for that": agree, then say the people who do fall for it said the same thing. Scammers are professionals who do this all day. The plan is just a backup, like a smoke alarm.

If they've already lost money, lead with kindness. Shame is why most people never report it, and why scammers come back for a second try.

2 The 30-minute plan

A. Pick a family safe word 5 min

Choose a word or phrase only the family knows, that isn't on social media. Anyone who calls in a panic asking for money has to say it. No word, no money: hang up and call them back on the number you already have. Say it out loud; don't text it or write it on the fridge.

B. Learn the 3 tells and 1 rule 5 min

Rush | **Secrecy** | **A strange way to pay**

The rule: hang up and call back on a number you look up yourself, from the back of the card, a statement, or the official website. Caller ID can be faked, so the name on the screen proves nothing.

C. Set up the phone together 10 min

- [ ] **Turn on spam call filtering** in the phone's settings or the carrier's free app, and consider silencing unknown callers (real callers leave a voicemail).
- [ ] **Install the latest updates** for the phone and its apps.
- [ ] **Look for remote-access apps** they don't recognise (like AnyDesk or TeamViewer) and remove any a stranger asked them to install.
- [ ] **Save the real numbers** for their bank, card company and pharmacy, with names like "BANK (real)".

D. Protect the money 10 min

- [ ] **Turn on transaction alerts** for their bank accounts and cards, so odd payments show up fast.
- [ ] **Ask about a trusted contact.** Many banks and brokerages let them name someone the firm can call if something looks wrong. The trusted contact can't move money.
- [ ] **Freeze their credit** at Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. It's free, doesn't affect their score, and stops new accounts in their name.
- [ ] **Agree on a "before you pay" call:** anything over an amount you pick together, they call you first. No judgement.

3 The 6 calls to hang up on

Go through these together. Ask "what would you say?" before reading the answer. A little role play helps it stick: you be the scammer.

If someone says…	Say this, then hang up
"Grandma, it's me. I'm in trouble and need bail money. Don't tell Mom."	"What's our family word?" No word: "I'll call you right back." Then call them, or their parents, on the number you already have.
"This is your bank's fraud department. Move your money to a safe account."	"I'll call the number on my card." No real bank asks you to move money to keep it safe.
"This is the IRS, Social Security or Medicare. You owe money, or your number is suspended."	"I'll contact the agency myself." They don't demand payment by phone or threaten arrest.
"Your computer has a virus. Let me connect to fix it." (or a pop-up with a number)	"No thanks." Don't call pop-up numbers. Close the browser or restart the computer.
"Pay with gift cards, a wire, crypto or a Bitcoin ATM."	"No." Anyone who asks for these is a scammer, every time. Gift cards are for gifts.
"You've won! Just pay the taxes and fees first."	"No thanks." Real prizes don't make you pay to collect them.

Texts and emails too: a toll, delivery or "account locked" message with a link? Don't tap. Open the real app or type the website yourself. Forward scam texts to 7726 (SPAM).

Online friends: someone they've never met in person who asks for money, or talks up an investment, is a scammer, however long they've been chatting.

4 Our family plan

Fill this in together and leave it by the phone. **Don't write the safe word here.**

Call first before any urgent payment

Card company's real number

Their number

"Call me first" amount: $

Second person to call

Credit freezes done (date)

Bank's real number (from the card)

Trusted contact named at

If something happens: call the bank on the number above, then call your family contact. Report it at ReportFraud.ftc.gov. Anyone offering to "recover" lost money for a fee is another scammer.

5 After you leave

- [ ] Text them one scam example a month: "Got this one, have you seen it?" It keeps the topic normal.
- [ ] Tell them they can forward you anything odd, any time, and you'll never be annoyed.
- [ ] Check in after big news stories about scams, tax season and the holidays.

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Leave something on the fridge. *Scam Decoded for Seniors* is our own large-print printable pack: a 13-page guide in 16-point type, a fridge checklist and cut-out wallet cards with the hang-up lines. Print it before you go home. **scamdecoded.netlify.app/seniors/**

General education, not legal or financial advice. Checked November 2026; confirm details with the official source. Example calls are composites. The $7 pack is our own product.